

THE ZCASH CEREMONY

037 / 22–23 OCT 2016 / ZCASH / UNCOMMON

ONE HONEST WITNESS

Before Zcash could launch, its first shielded protocol needed public parameters. On 22–23 October 2016, six witnesses used multi-party computation to produce the proving and verifying keys for Sprout. The network launched on 28 October, several days after the ceremony.

The setup's secret byproducts were called toxic waste: combined, they could enable counterfeit Zcash. Under the protocol's assumptions, one honest, uncompromised participant securely destroying their private contribution was enough to prevent reconstruction. Recovering the combined secret required every participant to be dishonest or compromised. This did not remove all trust or rule out other software and cryptographic flaws.

The witnesses worked in separate geographic locations, with offline compute machines and removed wireless radios. Write-once DVDs carried messages across the air gap and preserved evidence. Cryptographic security depended on physical precautions as well as mathematics.

The six participants were Zooko Wilcox, Andrew Miller, Peter Van Valkenburgh, Derek Hinch, Peter Todd and Edward Snowden. Snowden took part under the name John Dobbertin; his role became public in 2022. Todd's account records further hardware destruction on 24 October, after the computation had finished.

Six robed robots watch six separate circuit-marked scrolls burn in a brass bowl. The chapel and shared fire are a fictional composite, not a meeting of the real human participants or a record of burning paper. Each scroll stands for a private setup contribution, not a wallet key. Public proving and verifying parameters survive; the scene is about destroying the secrets, not combining them.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 SIX WITNESSES

Six robed robots stand for six human witnesses. Their shared chapel brings geographically separate stations into one fictional scene; the robots are not portraits of the actual participants.

02 SIX SEPARATE SECRETS

Count the six circuit-marked scrolls in the bowl. Each represents a separate private setup contribution, not a wallet key or the public parameters. The markings are invented, not readable cryptographic instructions.

03 THE CONSUMING FIRE

Flames eat the separate scrolls rather than fuse them into a master secret. This pictures secure destruction of private setup material; the public proving and verifying parameters were kept, not burned.

04 AN IMAGINED CHAPEL

Stained glass, candles and a moonlit castle give the ceremony a solemn visual setting. The chapel and its decorative emblems are invented scenery, not a historical venue or official Sprout insignia.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: ceremony record; ECC design account; Sprout launch date; Todd's account; Snowden confirmation. The six robots, shared chapel, brass bowl, circuit scrolls and decorative emblems are fictional. No robot is a portrait. Burning represents secure destruction of separate private setup contributions, not wallet keys or public parameters. ONE HONEST WITNESS is editorial wording, not a quotation.